

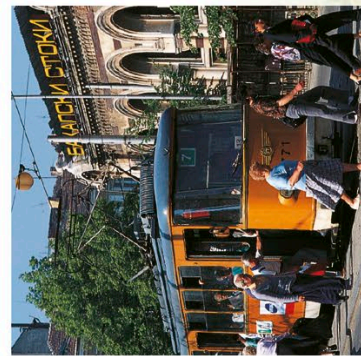
Bulgaria and Greece

FOR MORE THAN FOUR CENTURIES Bulgaria and Greece were ruled by the Ottoman Turks. Bulgaria gained independence in 1908, while southern Greece became independent in 1832 and was joined by northern Greece in 1913. After World War II, Bulgaria became a communist state. Both states are now democracies and members of the European Union (EU). Bulgaria remains relatively poor. Greece's economy is struggling, despite the billions of euros lent by the EU since 2010. That's when it was discovered that seemingly wealthy Greece had a huge national deficit (meaning it had spent a lot more than it had collected in taxes). Although they border each other, Bulgaria and Greece are quite different; the Greek mainland is mountainous with only one-third of the land suitable for cultivation. By contrast, Bulgaria is more fertile with a strong agricultural tradition. Tourism is an important source of income to both countries, with visitors flocking to the Black Sea resorts in Bulgaria, to the Greek mainland to see the ancient ruins, and to the Greek islands in search of sandy beaches.

First held in Athens in 1896, the modern Olympic Games were staged there again in 2004.

BULGARIAN AGRICULTURE

Wheat, corn, and other cereals grow in the fertile Danube river valley in the north of the country. Tobacco (right) grows in the Maritsa river valley in the southeast, while grapes for the wine industry flourish on the slopes of the Balkan Mountains. The festival of Kukerov Den, with traditional processions, celebrates the start of the agricultural year.

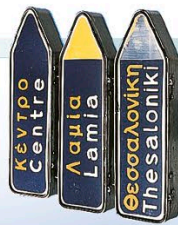
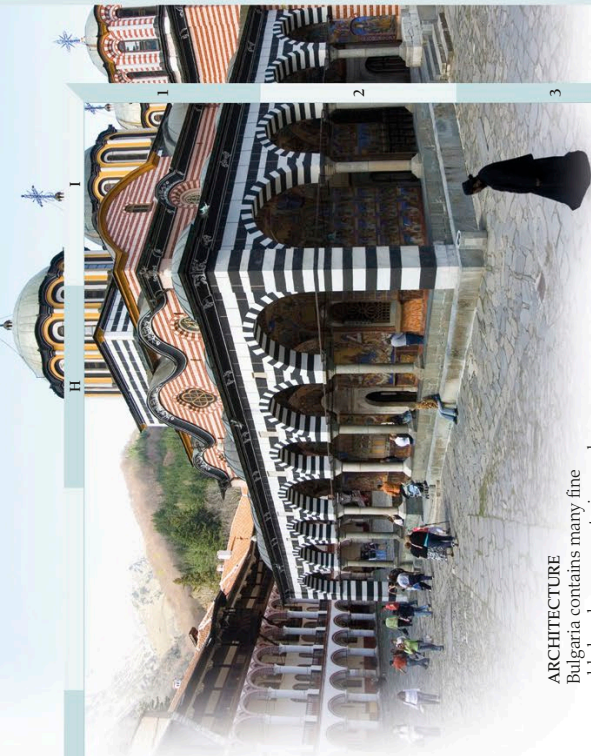


Trams provide an efficient way for people to get around Bulgaria's capital, Sofia.

CITY LIFE
Bulgarians make up about 77 percent of the total population of the country. Most of the rest are Turkish, Macedonian, or Roma. Most people live in apartment blocks in the main towns and cities. They are more likely to use public transportation as not all households have a car.

ARCHITECTURE

Bulgaria contains many fine old churches, monasteries, and mosques, despite the damage done to the country during World War II. Rila Monastery (above) was founded by a hermit monk who took to the mountains in search of solitude in 927 CE. After a fire in 1833, Rila was rebuilt and the magnificent church now boasts three great domes, a museum, and 1,200 frescoes.



LANGUAGE
The 24 characters in the Greek alphabet date from the 8th century BCE, when the first texts were written in classical Greek. Since then the language has evolved and is now spoken by 13 million people around the world.